



Niyam Bhushan

Facebook is the New Medusa

You must slay this terrible goddess of privacy-invasion.

Her head is a coil of deadly serpentine cables that tangle across the Web. They hiss and goad you to come forth to her Hades corner on her sleepless site, the aptly named Facebook.com.

Yes, it is the cursed face mortals dread to look at. One gaze into the hypnotic eyes set deep into her seductive and beautiful face shall petrify you, literally turning you into stone. Your computer will stay frozen, locked up for precious hours everyday updating your status, checking the news-feed of your fellow-victims—your friends, like you, entrapped by choice and circumstance. In your stupor, you fail to see that she breaks with impudence the locks around your privacy. How do you turn your eyes away from this terrifying new Medusa of the digital age, whose vicious laughter reverberates across data-streams on the Net?

Seeds of discontent

Atul Mohan, an ancient mariner of geeks, is the first one to point me the way—Diaspora, it is called. A new and alternative challenger to Facebook, it claims to be “privacy-aware, personally-controlled, do-it-all distributed open-source social network.” Big words there, but it promises you a fresh start, where you are lord and master of all your data and your privacy.

Audaciously, the team of four NYU computer-science students behind JoinDiaspora.com raised seed capital through kickstarter.com, inviting the community at large to donate USD 10,000 for their noble cause. Atul is one of those who promptly donated USD 50. With 16 days of the original 39 days still to go, the four founding Titans of Diaspora have already raised more than USD 170,000.

Is Diaspora going to slay Medusa-the-Facebook? Everybody's pinning their hopes on this promise, but look carefully at the fine-print. Says the website: “...will aggregate all of your information: your Facebook profile, tweets, anything.” Then again: “...will keep pulling tweets and you will still be able to see your Facebook newsfeed.” Eh! That really does sound counter-productive.

Hop over to another alternative to Facebook, called Elgg. Voted the “Best Open Source Social Networking Platform” by InfoWorld in 2008, Elgg is downloaded over 700 times per day, and has an active developer community contributing code and plug-ins. So if you are an educational or government institution, or even a business, which needs to create its own

‘social intranet,’ you can roll your own Elgg site, muft and mukt. Hint: LinuxForYou should be using Elgg rather than bouncing users to its Facebook page. Alas, Elgg too makes no bones about optionally feeding the Facebook monster, should users wish to do so.

Vanishing cream

Facebook won't die yet. The reason is in its Alexa rating. Facebook is the number two website in the world, with over 400 million users and growing. With a reach like that, and the newer Facebook ‘Like’ icon touching millions of other websites, here at last is a single platform, in over 70 languages, bigger than any print media or TV channel in the world. And yet it feels so personal to every single user. Who'd want to get off this magnet of eye-balls, privacy be damned. No wonder people

spend over 500 billion minutes per month on Facebook. Yet I insist, the damage to privacy can be devastating, especially when it applies to children or adolescents. It can destroy someone's career and reputation, or a relationship,

with an inadvertent or fraudulent post or comment. Be kind enough not to check out lamebook.com. There's a reason every government in the world has a smattering of privacy laws.

Facebook's team seems determined not to allow its users in the decision-making process. The internal team suddenly launches a new feature, and then has everyone scrambling for cover, if one is available. Facebook brazenly downplays the negative impact of violations of users' privacy, stating that users can choose to get off the social web if they're not interested. US senators are jumping into the controversy, and the European Union is beginning to rattle its sabre. I suppose the eventual solution may just be a cynical one: lawsuits, public-interest litigations, individual government policies, and legal pressure by NGOs and organisations like the EFF. This is inevitable; even the powerful Medusa could not escape her fate at the hands of Perseus. **END** 

“Who'd Want to Get Off This Magnet of Eye-Balls, Privacy Be Damned.”

About Niyam Bhushan

Inspired by the vision of Osho. Copyright June 2010: Niyam Bhushan, freedomyugs at gmail dot com. First published in LinuxForYou magazine. Verbatim copying, publishing and distribution of this article is encouraged in any language and medium, so long as this copyright notice is preserved. In Hindi, ‘muft’ means ‘free-of-cost’, and ‘mukt’ means ‘with freedom.’